6.5 Parliamentary form of government

Modern democratic governments are classified into parliamentary and presidential on the basis of nature of relations between the executive and the legislative organs of the government.



The parliamentary system of government is the one in which the executive is responsible to the legislature for its policies and acts. The presidential system of government, on the other hand, is one in which the executive is not responsible to the legislature for its policies and acts, and is constitutionally independent of the legislature in respect of its term of office.

The parliamentary government is also known as cabinet government irresponsible government or Westminster model of government and is prevalent in Britain, Japan, Canada, India among others.

Ivor Jennings called the parliamentary system as 'cabinet system' because the cabinet is the nucleus of power in a parliamentary system. The parliamentary government is also known as 'responsible government' as the cabinet (the real executive) is accountable to the Parliament and stays in office so long as it enjoys the latter's confidence.

It is described as 'Westminster model of government' after the location of the British Parliament, where the parliamentary system originated. In the past, the British constitutional and political experts described the Prime Minister as 'primus inter pares' (first among equals) in relation to the cabinet. In the recent period, the Prime Minister's power, influence and position have increased significantly vis-a-vis the cabinet. He has come to play a 'dominant' role in the British politico-administrative system.

Features of parliamentary form of government

Nominal and Real Executives: The President is the nominal executive (de jure executive or titular executive) while the Prime Minister is the real executive (de facto executive). Thus, the President is head of the State, while the Prime Minister is head of the government.

Majority Party Rule: The political party which secures majority seats in the LokSabha forms the government. The leader of that party is appointed as the Prime Minister by the President; other ministers are appointed by the President on the advice of the prime minister. However, when no single party gets the majority, a coalition of parties may be invited by the President to form the government.

Collective Responsibility: This is the bedrock principle of parliamentary government. The ministers are collectively responsible to the Parliament.

Double Membership: The ministers are members of both the legislature and the executive.

Leadership of the Prime Minister: The Prime Minister plays the leadership role

11th Std Political Science Eng Medium Vol-1 Page 143-170 Chapter 6.indd 94 2/5/2020 4:01:15 PM